

order to keep afloat, a necessity born out of lower wages and increased health care and housing costs. One nightmare viral post that circulated last year showed a ride-sharing app congratulating a new mom who drove into her ninth month of pregnancy. Why does this need to happen in a First World country? Why do our homes need to become hotels? Why do our cars need to become taxis? Why do we need to be working past work hours? How could I be a full-time reporter or content creator at a media company, working sometimes more than forty hours a week, and still need another job? (I mean, I know how, but you get it.)

In 2015, I channeled my frustrations into an article for *Fusion*, “Get Rich or Die Vlogging: The Sad Economics of Internet Fame.” In the piece, I revealed that the videos I was creating were costing me more money than I was making. I described scenes of me crying as I searched for quarters in my car and other very unglamorous aspects of my life that surprised a lot of my followers.

But here’s how it works. YouTubers are paid through the ads that play before their videos, facilitated through Google AdSense. Advertisers can choose what sort of content they want their ads to appear on. YouTube is allowing advertisers to opt out of LGBTQ content, which is basically my bread and butter. Even before these new advertising rules, the AdSense checks were notoriously small. One friend said she makes 89 cents per video. Right now, in 2018, Allison and I have 750,000 YouTube subscribers, and we make about \$4,000 a month, which we split. (This again, thankfully, covers my rent and bills, but *only* my rent and bills.) Back when we started, it was *much* less.

In my *Fusion* article, I wrote about my friend Brittany Ashley, who was one of the most popular actresses on BuzzFeed’s multimillion subscriber channels but who also worked as a waitress to survive. “Customers had approached her at work before, starstruck but confused,” I wrote in the article, “‘*Why would someone with 90,000 Instagram followers be serving brunch?*’ Simple: because Ashley needed the money. And yet, she said, ‘as I started having more visibility on the internet, I had to scale back on serving people.’ Her wallet took the hit, and so did her pride. ‘My coworkers would tell me a table of kids was freaking out [about seeing me] and I’m like, ‘What? Am I going to go say hi and take a picture in my work uniform?’”